A TECHIE'S MARKET

THE GROWING DEMAND FOR DIGITAL SPECIALISTS DURING THE PANDEMIC AND THEIR LIMITED SUPPLY REVVED UP THE TECH JOBS MARKET AND TECHIES FOUND THEMSELVES BESET WITH MULTIPLE OFFERS AND FANTASTIC COMPENSATION. HOW LONG WILL THE BOOM LAST?

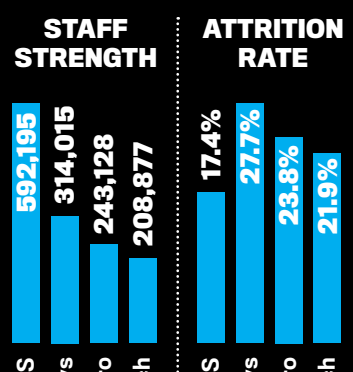
By **AJAY SUKUMARAN** | *Illustration by* **NILANJAN DAS**

Job Profile

$227 billion
Size of the sector

4.5 million
No. of those employed in the IT/ ITES sector

22.7 per cent
Industry attrition rate [mean of top four IT Indian services companies]



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K.R. GURU PRASAD IS RIDING a crest these days. The 36-year-old Bengaluru-based tech professional is currently in the process of switching jobs and has two offers in hand. "If you are good," he says, "you are getting a lot of offers. Especially in the last 15 days of your notice period. It's like a bidding process."

Indeed, it has never been a better time for software engineers. Or a more harrowing one for tech companies. A manager at the Bengaluru-based global capability centre (GCC) of an American IT firm says he has lost about 75 hands—at all levels—in the past five months despite the high pay packages. Jobs in the information technology sector in India are experiencing a boom cycle they haven't seen in a while. Tech companies are outdoing each other for lateral hires. It's as Kamal Karanth, co-founder of the specialist staffing firm Xpheno, puts it, "clearly a candidate's market".

India's $227 billion (Rs 17 lakh crore) IT and IT-enabled services sector currently has a workforce of about 4.5 million. Tata Consultancy Services (TCS), the largest company, boasts a staff strength of 590,000, followed by Infosys with 310,000, Wipro at 240,000 and HCL Technologies 208,000.

This trend of companies in hot pursuit of talent, precipitating the current churn in the sector, seems to be an aberration, points out Siva Prasad Nanduri, vice president, IT Staffing at TeamLease. "This is purely because of the tech stack changing and the gap